

DOWN FILMY LANE: (clockwise from top left) posters of Sridevi and Shah Rukh Khan; exhibits at *Bollywood Superstars*; Rajput armour and 19th-century coats; daggers; a 19th-century painting of Krishna dancing with female cowherds

ema has progressed to release over 1,500 films a year in almost 20 languages. Mythology and religion have been a constant source of inspiration for Indian filmmakers. The exhibition presents this relationship through stunning paintings, including the likes of the first attempts at motion picture drawing from Lord Krishna's stories.

Indian cinema has now grown to act as a public forum where contemporary social and cultural debates are played out. Through everyone from Madhubala to Madhuri Dixit to Deepika Padukone, *Bollywood Superstars* pays tribute to the industry's contribution to popular culture, of special consequence at a time when Indian films are doing the rounds of the Golden Globes and Oscars.

Among the glistening swords and other relics used in films influenced by the Mughal era, one notable feature of the exhibition is the wall dedicated to posters by Raja Ravi Varma. From Indian mythology to Vedic verses, his chromolithographs have inspired image-making in the subcontinent. Even the Father of Indian Cinema, Dadasaheb Phalke, drew from his work.

While the title betrays a partiality to Bollywood, there is a nod to the diversity of cinema from all four corners of the country. A significant section is dedicated to Bengali filmmaker Satyajit Ray. A visionary director best known for legendary films like *Pather Panchali* (1955) and *Aparajito* (1956), the still frames and screen showcasing just one scene from his movies are enough to leave you captivated.

Of course, no exhibition about Indian cinema would be complete without honouring superstar Rajinikanth. The video at the entrance of that section adequately displays the hero worship that grips most Indians, bordering on fervent devotion.

Along with the literal larger-than-life posters of popular stars, there is an interactive section that lets you shake a leg alongside them. One also can't miss out on the complementary activities, including special film screenings, workshops and talks.

While some Bollywood enthusiasts might miss stars like Rajesh Khanna or Rekha, the exhibition does make an earnest attempt to explore 'filmi culture'. If nothing, you can catch an evergreen screening of *Sholay* (1975) with family and friends. And, of course, take pride in watching the world soak in what, essentially, feels like home. ■

Caroline Felicia D'Almeida
(Bollywood Superstars *is showing at the Louvre Abu Dhabi till June 4)*

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ma', became viral, setting off a dance challenge on TikTok with enthusiasts recreating it in different settings.

On their maiden trip to India from March 11-17, the dancers were eager to return the love they have received from India, which accounts for nearly half their fan base on social media. Quick Style routinely shares reels and nifty routines to Hindi film and Punjabi songs now. Dancing to an A.R. Rahman tune or a Sukhbir classic, Quick Style showcases a movement vocabulary that emphasises feeling as much as technique. "It's like eating curry—it just feels good," says Suleman about the crew's penchant for dancing to desi beats. "We feel like we have so much more to give to this region not just in terms of fun and humour, but in terms of contributing a new style and flavour and making it more international."

For the Pakistani-Norwegian Malik brothers who started the group in 2006 along with Thai-Norwegian Nasir Sirikhan, Bollywood was an integral part of growing up. One of their earliest dance videos is of the twins moving to dhol beats—they were just two. "During the day, there was music daily in the house," say the brothers, "Coming home from school, we saw our sisters practise the routines. We pretended we weren't watching, but we were."

- Indian dance group you follow **Kings United**
- Favourite Indian dancer **Prabhu Deva**
- Artists on your playlist **A.R. Rahman, Stereo Nation**

Central to Quick Style's appeal—apart from the feelgood choreography, impressive dance moves and general swagger—is its multiculturalism. The 12 members are from diverse backgrounds and include a Swede, a Moroccan-Finn, a Sri Lankan and even an Indian in Kunal Bhart. "It helps us bring different stuff to the table," says David Wu, who is half-Taiwanese, half-Vietnamese. "Sharing the love between cultures is what we stand for." With a week in Mumbai, which saw them greet fans at a mall and collaborate with Virat Kohli, the group is eager to return. Asked if they'd like to start a studio here, the answer is a unanimous "Why not!". ■

Suhani Singh